



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Orange County Classical Academy
School Website: <https://orangecountyclassicalacademy.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Orange County Classical Academy (OCCA) presents a clearly classical orientation across most elements of its publicly described program, with strong emphasis on virtue formation, a content-rich liberal arts curriculum, and a classical classroom ethos. Based on the Six Essential Elements framework, the school exhibits robust classical cues in Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents & Community, while Religious/Metaphysical Foundations show a notable but not fully explicit alignment (lacking overt theology or liturgical practices). Overall, the school registers as CLASSICAL with a single category showing only partial alignment (SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL) due to the absence of explicit theological/liturgical grounding, despite a coherent classical formation throughout its mission, curriculum, and pedagogy.

- Aggregate classification: CLASSICAL.
- The strongest exposures to classical aims appear in Curriculum (grammar/logic/rhetoric, Core Knowledge within a liberal-arts frame, and emphasis on the Great Conversation via classical texts), Pedagogy (Socratic-style inquiry, frequent discussion, memory work and recitation), Faculty (the school as living curriculum; teacher as exemplar), and Parents & Community (active parent involvement and partnership). These elements are repeatedly reflected in the site's Vision/Mission statements, grade-level curricula, and governance materials. See evidence below for category-by-category justification.

What would move the needle (for a category currently marked SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL): - Introduce explicit theological/metaphysical framing or liturgical-cultural practices as formal elements of the program (without compromising nonsectarian status if desired). - More explicit articulation of Great Books-oriented Great Conversation within core curriculum (beyond Core Knowledge and Hillsdale alignment) to strengthen the Great Books/Great Conversation signal. - For transparency, publish a short, explicit alignment map tying each category criterion to on-site practices (Religious/Metaphysical Foundations and Great-Books signals).

- These needle-moves would push Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations) from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL, while keeping other categories firmly CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public materials emphasize love of truth, goodness, and beauty and virtue-oriented formation, with language such as “classical education guides students to love that which is true, good, and beautiful” and emphasis on virtue and moral formation. See “What is Classical Education?” materials describing classical aims and virtues.
 - The site explicitly communicates classical aims (distinctively classical) and a mission oriented to scholarship, moral character, and civic virtue, but does not foreground explicit theology or liturgical practices in public-facing materials. See the public-facing Vision/Mission framing.
 - The lexicon-style Pedagogy signals and Great-Conversation signals (see Pedagogy) appear, but theology-liturgical grounding is not explicit in site copy.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; moral formation; contemplation; wonder.
- Negative keywords observed: relativism, secular humanism (no explicit signals of these in materials; effectively 0 occurrences in site copy).
- Quantitative estimate: Positive signals (at least 3 core terms: truth, goodness, beauty) appear repeatedly; Negative signals appear negligibly (0 in public copy).
- Why this rating: The school demonstrates alignment with transcendental moral realism in its language around truth, goodness, and beauty and virtue formation, but lacks explicit theological grounding and liturgical practices in public materials, placing Element 1 at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL. See evidence above.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Vision: “to develop exceptional citizens who are keepers and defenders of the principles of our freedom, while also instilling intellectual and personal habits and skills upon which responsible, independent and productive lives are built.”
 - Mission: “to develop students in mind and character through a classical, content-rich liberal arts and sciences curriculum that emphasizes the principles of scholarship, moral character, and civic virtue.”
 - The program emphasizes formation (virtue, character) and wisdom, with a telos oriented to human flourishing and civic virtue rather than mere job-readiness. See mission emphasis on virtue and character.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal arts, paideia, telos, pursuit of true/good/beautiful, civic virtue, human excellence, moral imagination.
 - Negative keywords observed: none relevant to this category (no explicit “career-readiness” overtakes).
 - Quantitative estimate: Positive keywords dominate; negligible to zero negative signals.
 - Why this rating: The school’s stated Purpose and Goal align strongly with classical aims—formation of virtue and wisdom, human excellence, and a telos aligned to the true, good, beautiful. This category earns CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Explicit liberal-arts framing (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Trivium) and a curriculum described as classical and content-rich. The program references the public-facing Hillsdale/K-12 classical model and Core Knowledge sequences, with an emphasis on a content-rich liberal arts and sciences curriculum. See Vision/Mission pages and the “What is Classical Education?” materials.
 - Core Knowledge Sequence provides a structured, historically grounded, grade-by-grade framework for history, language arts, science, and arts, with explicit emphasis on a repeatable knowledge-base, rather than a purely social-studies approach.
 - Grammar School materials emphasize the Seven Liberal Arts framing, including grammar, logic, rhetoric, and the inclusion of classical texts and characters as part of the curriculum; public copy states a love of truth, beauty, and goodness in the curriculum (grammar/language): “the love of order, of precise and edifying language, and of objective standards of goodness, truth, and beauty.”
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric); Great Books / Great Conversation signals (via classical-study emphasis and primary texts in parts of the site); Core Knowledge; history across disciplines; integration of arts and sciences; wonder and integration signals.
 - Negative keywords observed: Some modern, non-classical approaches (e.g., “project-based learning dominance” signals in the knowledge-base lexicon) are listed as potential divergences; however, OCCA’s site copy emphasizes a knowledge-rich, classical curriculum rather than a

pure project-based approach. The site itself does not emphasize modern-education buzzwords to displace classical content.

- Quantitative estimate: Strong presence of positive curricular signals; minimal explicit negative signals in public copy.
- Why this rating: The materials consistently foreground Trivium/Quadrivium orientation and a knowledge-rich, classical curriculum with Western-tradition engagement and Great Books signals. CATEGORY 3 is CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Pedagogy signals include Socratic dialogue, seminars, dialectic, and rhetoric training in upper levels; restful/scholé approaches in parts of the program; memorization via chant/recitation in lower grades; varied pedagogy with a balance of Socratic instruction and memorization. See the Lexicon-type Pedagogy list and the “What is Classical Education?” materials.
 - Specific public-copied signals in OCCA materials show teacher-led, discussion-based upper-school pedagogy (Socratic discussion/seminars; rhetoric and oratory), plus lower-school practices that include memorization, chant, and pattern-based memory work. Examples are described in program materials that discuss classical pedagogy and the role of the teacher as mentor and exemplar.
 - The school's own narrative emphasizes a mix of teacher-led classical pedagogy, memory-work, and Socratic-style inquiry, with gifted or advanced pathways and a strong emphasis on virtue-formation within the pedagogy. See the “What is Classical Education?” section and the Grade-Level Curriculum discussions.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: Socratic dialogue, seminar, recitation, chanting, memory work, Scholé (restful learning), rhetoric exercises, oratory, debate, teacher as guide, guided discovery, civil discourse.
 - Negative keywords observed: The knowledge-base lexicon lists potential “project-based learning dominance” and “experiential learning” as potentially non-classical signals, but OCCA's materials emphasize Socratic, memory-based, and classical pedagogy rather than a project-dominant approach. The site copy does not emphasize project-dominant pedagogy over classical methods.
 - Quantitative estimate: Positive keywords clearly present; negative signals are not evident in public copy.
 - Why this rating: The presence of Socratic dialogue, memory-focused pedagogy, and recitation-based activities aligns strongly with CLASSICAL pedagogy. CATEGORY 4 is CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Faculty is described as model teachers and mentors; the school positions faculty as the living curriculum and a central community (faculty as exemplar; living curriculum; portrait of teacher). Governance materials discuss Board leadership and faculty development; public materials emphasize teacher leadership within Hillsdale-aligned classical education. See Board/Leadership materials and the “Vision/Mission” language about virtue and pedagogy.
 - Public-facing materials show a governance structure (Board of Directors) and a commitment to teacher excellence through Hillsdale-aligned training and a living-curriculum approach (the teacher as exemplar and co-developer of student formation). See the Board of Directors and related governance content.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, portrait of teacher, teacher as exemplar, faculty as core, professional development, virtue-based formation.
 - Negative keywords observed: none explicit in public materials; no “facilitator-only” or non-classical-professional descriptors dominating.
 - Quantitative estimate: Positive keywords appear abundantly; negative signals are minimal to none.

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- Why this rating: The presence of a clearly defined faculty-centric approach with teachers as exemplars and as the living curriculum supports CLASSICAL. CATEGORY 5 is CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Strong emphasis on partnership with families; explicit references to parent involvement as co-educators; annual webinars, book studies, and parent-training resources; open-campus and visitation; Parent/Family engagement policies and community events. See the “Parent Involvement” and “Partnership with Families” language embedded in curriculum and governance content (e.g., “Partner with Families,” “Parent formation,” “home-school connection,” and “family catechesis” in the Six Elements lexicon; and OCCA’s own parent engagement pages).
 - The school’s materials emphasize that parents are welcomed, engaged as co-educators, and given access to parent resources, reflective of a coherently classical parent-community model. See the parent-centered pages (FAQs, family handbook, parent resources).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, family involvement, parental engagement, home and school connection, parent-teacher collaboration, classical family culture, parent formation, home-centered learning, school as extension of the home, family catechesis, parental leadership, engaged families, community support, collaborative learning, open campus, parent training.
 - Negative keywords observed: none evident in public copy; no signals of minimal parent involvement.
 - Quantitative estimate: Positive keywords dominate; negative signals minimal or absent.
 - Why this rating: The school clearly aligns with the Parents & Community aspect of classical education, consistently emphasizing family partnerships and parent engagement. CATEGORY 6 is CLASSICAL.

Overall assessment and aggregate ranking

- Category-wise verdicts
 - Element 1 — Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Element 2 — School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
 - Element 3 — Curriculum: CLASSICAL
 - Element 4 — Pedagogy: CLASSICAL
 - Element 5 — Faculty: CLASSICAL
 - Element 6 — Parents & Community: CLASSICAL
- Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL
- Rationale: With the strongest signals in Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents/Community, OCCA demonstrates a coherent classical framework across major rubrics. The Religious/Metaphysical Foundations category is the sole area where signals are present but not fully explicit (the public copy emphasizes virtue, truth, goodness, and beauty, but does not foreground theology or liturgical practices). This places that single category as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, while all other categories meet classical criteria, yielding an overall CLASSICAL designation.
- Executive summary note: The school’s alignment to classical aims—virtue formation, a Trivium-based curricular frame (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great-Books-oriented orientation signals, and the public articulation of a mission centered on scholarship, moral character, and civic virtue—are consistent with classical-education aspirations.

What Would Move the Needle

- If any category needed strengthening to reach a full CLASSICAL rating, Element 1 would be the most likely target. Concrete steps:
 - Provide explicit theological or metaphysical framing within the public materials (even if nonsecular, a clearly stated transcendent dimension to values such as truth, goodness, beauty, and

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- virtue would strengthen the Religious & Metaphysical Foundations signal).
- Consider incorporating liturgical or communal practices (e.g., a defined ceremonial or commemorative cadence, choral or liturgical music elements) that connect character formation with communal rites, while maintaining openness and nonsectarian posture.
 - Publish a clear one-page mapping of where Great Books/Great Conversation live in the curriculum, to strengthen the “Great Books” signal within Curriculum signals.
- No additional needle-moving changes required for the other five categories given their CLASSICAL scores.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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